

GO-TO-MARKET STRATEGY

Subscription Guardian

GTM Strategy & Financial Analysis

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Status: Pre-Launch • UK Market Focus

 UK-First

 Product-Led Growth

 Zero-Spend Validate

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Pricing: Free (one-time scan, 10 subs) + Premium £3.99/mo (auto-scan, unlimited, alerts)

Tags: #UKFintech #ProductLedGrowth #SubscriptionManagement #ChromeExtension

Executive Summary

~24M UK TAM (3+ SUBSCRIPTIONS)	2.5× PERCEPTION GAP (VIRAL HOOK)	£8.5K Y1 REVENUE (MODERATE)	5.7:1 LTV:CAC (ORGANIC)
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Subscription Guardian is a Chrome extension that scans Gmail for subscription receipts and reveals the gap between what users *think* they spend vs. what they *actually* spend. Market data confirms a **2.5× perception gap** — users estimate ~£68/mo while real spend averages ~£175/mo. This gap is the core growth engine:

"I thought I spent £65/mo on subscriptions. My Gmail says £180. Here's what I found." — post format that naturally generates viral Reddit threads

Year 1 Scenario Comparison

Metric	Conservative	Moderate	Aggressive
End-of-Year Premium Users	~100	~300	~840
Year 1 Revenue	~£3,500	~£8,500	~£20,000
Year 1 Costs	~£500	~£1,200	~£2,500
Net Profit (Y1)	~£3,000	~£7,300	~£17,500
Month to Breakeven	Month 4	Month 2	Month 1
LTV:CAC (Organic)	4.6:1	6.8:1	11:1

Core Thesis Confirmed: At £3.99/mo, Subscription Guardian is viable as a bootstrapped micro-SaaS generating **£500–2,000/mo MRR** within a year with zero marketing spend. Paid acquisition (PPC) is uneconomical at this price point. Growth must come entirely from organic/community distribution around the perception gap hook.

Product & Funnel

The Hook

Users connect Gmail via OAuth (read-only scope). The backend scans last 6 months of receipts and shows a **surprise gap** — "You think you spend £68/mo. You actually spend £175/mo. Here's where it's going." This revelation IS the marketing moment. Screenshots are inherently shareable.

Funnel Stages

Step	User Action	Conversion	Benchmark Source
1	Landing page visit	—	—
2	Click "Connect Gmail — Free"	13.5%	First Page Sage (fintech avg)
3	OAuth consent & scan	80%+	Internal estimate
4	See surprise gap dashboard	—	—
5	Upgrade to Premium (£3.99/mo)	5.2% blended	RevenueCat / First Page Sage
6	Annual upgrade (£39.99/yr)	~15% of premium	Industry benchmark

Conversion event = Step 4. If users don't see a meaningful gap, they won't convert. The free tier must deliver a "holy shit" moment.

Target Customer

Attribute	Detail
Geography	United Kingdom
Age	25–45, urban professionals
Subscriptions	3+ active (Netflix, Spotify, gym, cloud, meal kits)
Pain	"I have no idea what I'm paying each month"
Behaviour	Active on Reddit, uses Monzo/Revolut, checks deals, price-conscious
Trigger	Post-holiday guilt, Netflix price hike, "where's my money going?" moment
Tech comfort	Uses Chrome extensions, comfortable with OAuth

UK Addressable Market

Market Size

Metric	Value	Source
UK population (mid-2025)	69.5M	ONS
UK adults (18+)	~54M	ONS estimate
Internet users (97.8%)	~52.8M	DataReportal
Adults with ≥1 subscription	42.4M (80%)	Whistl / Barclays
Average subscriptions per person	2.8–5.6	Aqua Card / SQ Magazine
Monthly subscription spend (avg)	£50.60–£65.50	Barclays / Aqua Card

Addressable Funnel

Layer	Definition	Est. Size
TAM	UK adults with 3+ subscriptions (our ICP)	~24M
SAM	Gmail + Chrome users with 3+ subscriptions	~15–18M
SOM (Y1 Conservative)	Realistic first-year capture	~2,000 users
SOM (Y1 Aggressive)	If viral hits materialise	~25,000 users

Note: 17% of subscription-holders say they "never track what they're spending" — this ~7.2M cohort is the highest-intent audience. They already know they have a problem; they just need a solution.

Revenue Projections — Year 1

Conversion rates grounded in fintech benchmarks: Free signup 13.5% (First Page Sage), Premium conversion 5.2% blended (RevenueCat), annual adoption ~15% of premium base.

Conservative Scenario

Month	Visitors	Free Signups	Premium Paid	MRR	ARR Run Rate
1	3,000	405	21	£84	£1,007
2	1,000	135	7	£112	£1,343
3	800	108	6	£135	£1,625
Q2 avg	733	99	5	~£170	~£2,040
Q3 avg	900	122	6	~£250	~£3,000
Q4 avg	1,200	162	8	~£340	~£4,080
Year 1 End	~14,500 total	~1,960 total	~102 total	~£340 MRR	~£4,080 ARR

Revenue: ~£3,500 | Breakeven: Month 4

Moderate Scenario

Month	Visitors	Free Signups	Premium Paid	MRR	ARR Run Rate
1	8,000	1,080	56	£224	£2,688
2	3,000	405	21	£308	£3,695
3	2,500	338	18	£379	£4,544
Q2 avg	2,167	293	15	~£490	~£5,880
Q3 avg	2,750	371	19	~£700	~£8,400
Q4 avg	3,500	473	25	~£850	~£10,200
Year 1 End	~42,000 total	~5,670 total	~295 total	~£850 MRR	~£10,200 ARR

Revenue: ~£8,500 | Breakeven: Month 2

Aggressive Scenario

Month	Visitors	Free Signups	Premium Paid	MRR	ARR Run Rate
1	20,000	2,700	140	£560	£6,720
2	8,000	1,080	56	£784	£9,408
3	6,000	810	42	£952	£11,424
Q2 avg	5,333	720	37	~£1,200	~£14,400
Q3 avg	7,000	945	49	~£1,700	~£20,400
Q4 avg	10,000	1,350	70	~£2,100	~£25,200
Year 1 End	~120,000 total	~16,200 total	~840 total	~£2,100 MRR	~£25,200 ARR

Revenue: ~£20,000 | Breakeven: Month 1

Cost Structure

Monthly Costs by Scale

Cost Item	100 Users	500 Users	1,000 Users	5,000 Users
Railway Hosting	~£16	~£24	~£28	~£64
PostgreSQL	~£4	~£8	~£12	~£32
Domain	~£0.83	~£0.83	~£0.83	~£0.83
Stripe Fees	~£3	~£8	~£18	~£100
Google API	£0	£0	£0	£0
Email Service	£0	£0	~£12	~£40
GDPR/Tools	£0	£0	~£8	~£12
Total Monthly	~£24	~£41	~£79	~£249
Annualised	~£288	~£492	~£948	~£2,988

Key insight: Gmail API is effectively free at this scale (billion-unit quotas). The biggest variable cost is PostgreSQL storage as user data grows. Railway's free tier (\$5 credits) covers the first 3 months at low scale.

One-Time Setup Costs

Item	Cost	Notes
Domain (subscriptionguardian.co.uk)	~£10	
Chrome Web Store Registration	~£4	\$5 one-time fee
Legal / Privacy Policy Review	£200-500	Templated + tweak
ICO Registration (if required)	£0-40	Exempt for sole traders
Logo + Branding	£0-100	DIY or Fiverr
Total Setup	~£215-£655	

Year 1 All-In Cost (Moderate Scenario)

Category	Amount
Hosting (Railway Pro, 12mo)	~£350
Domain + Chrome Web Store	~£14
Legal / Privacy Review	~£300
Stripe Fees (on ~£8,500 revenue)	~£550
Marketing / Content	£0
Total Year 1 Burn	~£1,214
Revenue (Moderate)	~£8,500
Net Profit	+£7,286

Unit Economics

Customer Lifetime Value (LTV)

Churn Rate	Avg Lifetime (mo)	LTV (Monthly Only)	LTV (w/ 15% Annual Upgrades)
5%/mo (best case)	20	~£80	~£88
6.5%/mo (fintech avg)	15.4	~£61	~£68
8%/mo (consumer avg)	12.5	~£50	~£55

~£68 EXPECTED LTV	93.5% GROSS MARGIN	£0.26 VARIABLE COST / USER	Immediate BREAKEVEN / CUSTOMER
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Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC)

Channel	Cost per Premium User	Notes
Organic (explicit)	£0	No paid spend
Organic (implicit, founder time)	~£12	20-40 hrs/mo at £50/hr
Google Ads (PPC)	£220-500	✗ Uneconomical
Reddit / Community	£5-15	Best ROI channel

LTV:CAC Ratio

Scenario	LTV	CAC	Ratio	Verdict
Organic (implicit)	£68	£12	5.7:1	✓ Excellent
Organic (explicit)	£68	£0	∞:1	✓ At launch
Google Ads (PPC)	£68	£220-500	0.14-0.31:1	✗ Unprofitable
Content / SEO	£68	£15-30	2.3-4.5:1	● Viable

Critical finding: At £3.99/mo, paid acquisition (PPC) is nearly impossible to make profitable in the UK. Google Ads CPA of £220-500 far exceeds LTV of £68. This means: **stay organic until LTV improves (via price increase) or viral coefficient proves out.**

Revenue Multipliers

Lever	Potential Impact	Effort
Price increase (£3.99 → £5.99)	+50% ARPU	Low
Annual billing (£39.99/yr)	+15% LTV, -30% churn	Low
Referral program (1mo free)	+10-20% signups	Medium
UK finance blog guest post	+200-500 signups/post	Medium
Tiered pricing (add £5.99/mo plan)	+25-40% ARPU	Medium
Open Banking integration (future)	TAM expansion	High

Competitive & Industry Benchmarks

Competitor Landscape

Feature	SG	Emma (UK)	SubWiz	Rocket Money
Gmail scanning	✓	✗	✗	✗
Price hike alerts	✓	✗	✗	✓
Chrome extension	✓	✗	✗	✗
UK-focused	✓	✓	✓	✗
Auto-cancellation	✗ (MVP)	✓	✗	✓
Price	£3.99/mo	£4.99/mo	Free	\$3-12/mo

SG's wedge: Gmail scanning unearths subscriptions that users have forgotten about — subscriptions that bank-linked apps never see (Amazon Prime via credit card won't show as "subscription" in Open Banking). This is genuinely differentiated.

Real-World Benchmarks

Metric	Industry Data	SG Estimate	Source
Visitor → Free signup	13.5%	10-15%	First Page Sage
Free → Premium (fintech avg)	3.7%	3-6%	First Page Sage
Fintech monthly churn	5-8%	6-8%	Industry avg
Finance apps ARPU (top quartile)	\$4-8	£3.99	RevenueCat
Rocket Money revenue (2024)	\$297M	—	SEC filings
Emma total funding	\$7.3M	—	Crunchbase

Acquisition Channels

Phase 1: Zero-Spend Organic (Months 1-3)

Channel	Tactic	Est. Traffic	Cost
Reddit 	r/UKPersonalFinance, r/CasualUK — "I found £200/mo I forgot about"	10K-50K views/post	£0
Hacker News	Show HN with surprise gap stat + open source tease	5K-20K visits	£0
Product Hunt	Launch with "Find your forgotten subscriptions" hook	2K-10K visits	£0
TikTok / Reels	30s demo: "I found £147/mo in 30 seconds"	Viral potential	£0
SEO Content	"forgotten subscriptions UK", "hidden subscriptions check"	100-1K/mo (compounds)	£0 (DIY)

Expected conversion (organic): 10,000 visitors → 1,350 free signups → ~70 premium users. All at £0 direct cost.

Phase 2: Paid (Month 4+, after PMF)

Channel	Keyword / Audience	Est. CPC	Monthly Budget
Google Ads	"track subscriptions UK", "find forgotten payments"	£0.50-1.50	 Not recommended
Content Marketing	Blog posts + guest posts on UK finance sites	—	£200-500/mo
UK Finance Influencer	MoneySavingExpert-style bloggers	—	£200-500 (one-off)
Reddit Ads	r/UKPersonalFinance audience targeting	£0.30-0.80	£100-200/mo

Channel ROI Ranking

#	Channel	Cost	Expected CPA	Recommendation
1	Content + SEO	£0-200	~£15	 Launch now
2	Reddit (r/UKPersonalFinance)	£0	~£8	 Launch now
3	Product Hunt	£0	~£10	 Launch now
4	Hacker News	£0	~£12	 Launch now
5	Finance blogger outreach	£200-500	~£30	 Month 3+
6	TikTok / Reels	£0-100	~£20	 Try once
7	Google Ads (PPC)	£500-1,000	£220-500	 Avoid

Budget Recommendation

Phase 1: Validate (£54-569 one-time) — Now

Item	Cost	Priority
Domain + Chrome Web Store listing	£14	● Required
Privacy policy + ICO registration	£40-240	● Required
Cookie banner (self-host)	£0	● Required
Railway Hobby plan (3 months)	~\$15	● Required
Security docs for Google OAuth	£0-300	● High
Logo + brand	£0-100	● High
SEO content (2-3 articles)	£0 (DIY)	● High
Total	£54-569	

Phase 2: Launch & Iterate (£20-25/mo) — Months 1-6

Item	Monthly
Railway Pro	\$20/mo (~£16)
Overages / minor cloud costs	~£5-10
Analytics (self-host Plausible)	£0
Email (SendGrid free tier)	£0
Content (1-2 blog posts)	£0 (founder time)
Total	~£20-25/mo

Phase 3: Growth (£1,000-2,100/mo) — Month 6+

Only if moderate or aggressive scenario is materialising. Focus spend on content + influencer outreach, not PPC.

£54-569

PHASE 1 (SETUP)

£20-25/mo

PHASE 2 (LAUNCH)

**£1K-2K/
mo**

PHASE 3 (GROWTH)

Month 1-4

PROFITABILITY RANGE

Risk Matrix & Mitigations

Risk	Severity	Likelihood	Mitigation
Google OAuth verification denial	 High	Medium	Prepare thorough security docs. Test with <100 users first.
Low conversion (<2% free→paid)	 Medium	Low	A/B test pricing, upgrade prompts, onboarding flow
High churn (>8%/mo)	 Medium	Medium	Annual billing, dunning, onboarding emails
Gmail API rate limiting	 Medium	Low	Exponential backoff, batch API calls
Chrome extension review delays	 Medium	Medium	Submit early as "unlisted", build audience first
Competitor clones (Emma adds Gmail)	 Low	Low	First-mover in Chrome extension + Gmail scanning niche in UK
GDPR enforcement action	 Low	Low	ICO registration, clear privacy policy, encryption at rest
User trust barrier ("read my email??")	 Medium	Medium	Open-source backend, security white paper, independent audit

Final Verdict

✓ BUILD — Bootstrapped micro-SaaS

Subscription Guardian is viable as a bootstrapped lifestyle business. The 2.5× perception gap is a genuine viral asset, costs are near-zero, and the UK market has a verified white space (no competitor combines Gmail scanning + Chrome extension + UK focus).

Key constraints:

- £3.99/mo pricing makes paid acquisition uneconomical — stay organic
- Google OAuth verification at 100 users is the biggest external bottleneck
- Churn will be 6-8% without active retention work
- This is a £500-2,000/mo MRR business, not a VC moonshot

Minimum viable next steps: Domain → Privacy policy → Railway deploy → Reddit post. Total cost: ~£54. Time to first user: 1 weekend.

Research conducted May 2026 • Data from Barclays, Aqua Card, Ofcom, SQ Magazine, First Page Sage, RevenueCat, Stripe, Railway, ONS, DataReportal, and SEC filings.

SG

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